



Tribal Anthropology

Occupational & Linguistic Classifications

UPSC CSE — Anthropology Optional — Paper 2

Part 1 of Tribal India Series

Source: Sarrthi IAS — Thor × Team Avengers Handout

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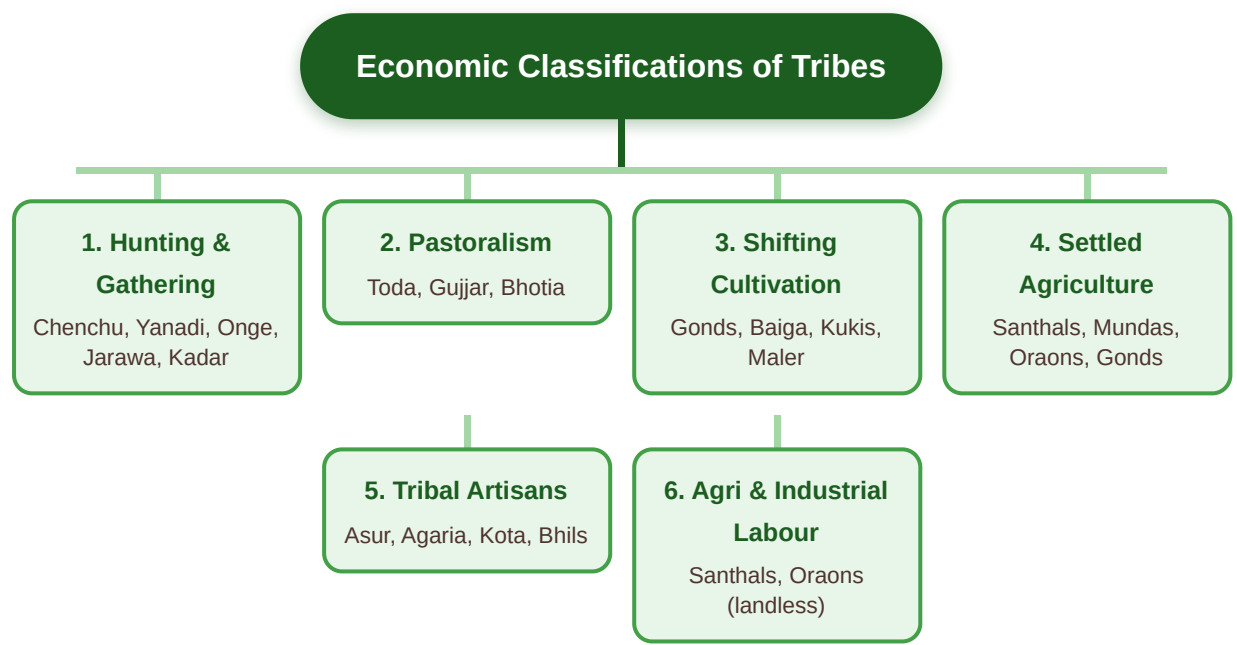
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Section 1: Occupational (Economic) Classifications of Tribes



1. Hunting and Gathering

Definition: *Foraging* = searching for and collecting food available in nature (fruits, vegetables, nuts, animals, fish) by gathering, fishing, or hunting. This is the **oldest economic system** since *Homo sapiens*.

 **Global Context**

Food gatherers = **0.004%** of world population. In India: mainly **South India** and **Andaman Islands**.

Features of Hunting-Gathering Societies

Feature	Detail
Simple technology	Few tools; digging stick, collection basket, bows and arrows, spears, boomerangs
Nomadism	Characterised by nomadism and semi-nomadism
Low population density	Total tribe rarely exceeds a few thousand; bands of 25–30
Small self-sufficient unit	Small nomadic band or semi-nomadic settlement
Division of labour	Men specialise in hunting; women specialise in food collection
No surplus	No surplus and no trade

 **Marshall Sahlins** — termed hunting-gathering societies the “**ORIGINAL AFFLUENT SOCIETY**” — affluence defined not by material accumulation but by *satisfaction through balance with nature*.

Sustainability of Hunting-Gathering

- Limited extraction and seasonal rotation of resource zones
 - Ritual taboos on hunting during breeding seasons
 - Collective ownership and sharing norms prevent hoarding
 - Deep ecological knowledge transmitted through oral traditions, songs, and myths
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Case Studies: Hunting-Gathering Tribes



(a) Chenchu — Andhra Pradesh

- **Location:** Nallamala Hills of AP and Telangana
- **Subsistence:** Forest foods, honey, roots, small game
- Seasonal foraging cycles based on rainfall and fruiting
- Deep ecological knowledge of flora and fauna
- **Customs:** Hunting restrictions during breeding; collective sharing of meat and honey; belief in forest spirits



(b) Yanadi — AP, Tamil Nadu

- **Location:** Nellore and Chittoor, near lakes and estuaries
- Skilled fisherfolk and crab catchers; bamboo traps and hand-woven nets
- Men fish and hunt small animals; women gather wild fruits, roots, medicinal herbs
- Remarkable knowledge of tides, fish migration, wetland ecology



(c) Onge — Little Andaman

- Negrito tribe; hunting, gathering, fishing in coastal and forest zones
- **Diet:** Fish, turtle, pig, honey, yams
- Egalitarian sharing norms prevent accumulation
- **Ritual restrictions:** Forbid hunting pregnant animals or overharvesting yams



(d) Jarawa — Andaman Islands

- Coastal and forest belt hunter-gatherers
- **Subsistence:** Wild pigs, fish, honey, tubers, fruits
- Excellent navigational and bow-hunting skills
- **Custom:** Group sharing and ritual purification before hunting; symbolic reciprocity reinforces social cohesion



(e) Kadar — Kerala

- **Location:** Anamalai and Nelliampathy hills
- Skilled honey, wax, and forest produce collectors; knowledge of elephant trails and herbs
- Often forest guides and elephant catchers for the state
- Subsistence combines foraging and seasonal wage work — adaptation to ecological and market changes



Fishing as Subsistence

Likely developed parallel to hunting. Groups use nets, traps, harpoons, canoes.

Examples: Yanadi near Pulicat Lake; Onge along coastal reefs.

Conclusion

These tribes demonstrate **intimate harmony with ecosystems**. Their customs, taboos, and social structures ensure resource renewal and community equality. Even as modernisation forced many to abandon these livelihoods, their ethos of *respect for nature* remains a lesson in sustainable living.

2. Pastoralism

Definition: A *transitional phase* between food collection and food production. Subsistence through domestication of animals. Found in areas **not suitable for agriculture**.

Features of Pastoral Societies

Feature	Detail
Small population	Move from place to place for food for domesticated animals
Domestication of animals	Only occupation where rainfall not suitable for agriculture
Semi-nomadism	Constant movement for grazing
Transhumance	Part of population moves seasonally with herds; others remain home

Examples

Todas (buffaloes, Nilgiris) • **Gujjar** (sheep) • **Tschembago** (pigs) • **Bhotias** (Uttarakhand)

Major Case Study: Nilgiri Hills Traditional Interdependence

Nilgiri Hills Ecosystem — Tamil Nadu

Ethnographic Context: Nilgiri Hills (Tamil Nadu) — home to **Toda, Kota, Kurumba, Irula** + non-tribal **Badaga**. Each occupies a specialised ecological and occupational niche.

Economic and Social Interdependence

Community	Role & Interdependence
Toda	Pastoralists herding sacred buffalo; produce milk, curd, ghee; depend on others for grains and craft goods
Kota	Artisans and blacksmiths; pottery, metal tools, carpentry; ritual musicians at Toda ceremonies
Irula	Hunters and gatherers; trapping, snake catching, pest control; supply forest produce to Badagas
Badaga	Agriculturalists; cultivate grains and vegetables; exchange food with Todas; hire Irulas and Kurumbas
Kurumba	Forest collectors and medicine-men; honey, wax, roots, herbs; shamanic healing for other groups

Mechanisms of Exchange

- **Barter:** Toda dairy products traded for Badaga grains or Kota crafts
- **Ritual Ties:** Toda ceremonies require Kota musicians and Kurumba priests
- **Reciprocity and Respect:** Interdependence governed by mutual obligations, not market pricing

Cultural and Ecological Balance

- Sacred dairies managed by Toda priests — only ritually pure men may enter
- Buffalo milk used in offerings — symbolises link between humans, animals, gods
- Kota craft and Kurumba healing with ritual restrictions prevent resource overuse

Changes in Nilgiri

- **Monetisation:** Tea/vegetable plantations, roads, tourism converted barter into cash
- **Occupational Shifts:** Kotas to modern carpentry; Kurumbas/Irulas to plantation labour; Todas supply milk to Aavin cooperatives
- **Cultural Revival:** NGOs and anthropologists promote Toda embroidery and Kota pottery

Significance

Self-regulating, multi-ethnic economy. Traditional customs ensured resource diversity, reciprocity, ecological restraint. Cultural memory of interdependence inspires collective identity and environmental respect.

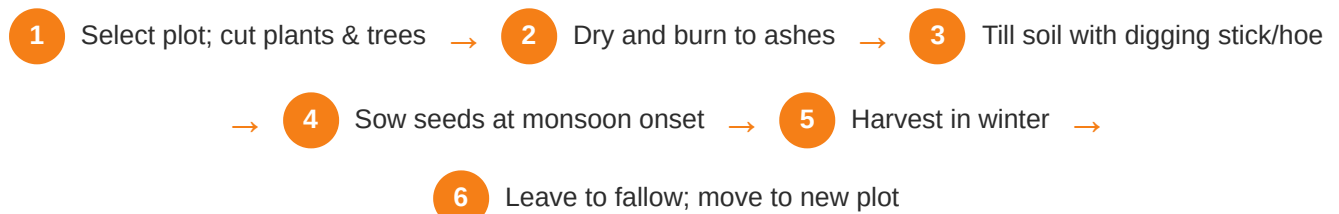
3. Shifting Cultivation

- Primary source of subsistence for many tribal communities
- Distinct agriculture on hill slopes. Dates back to **Neolithic times (8,000–10,000 years ago)**
- Transition from nomadic to settled life
- **Also known as:** Jhum (NE India), Bewar (Baiga), Podu, Kumri
- Also found in: Sumatra, North Burma, Borneo, New Guinea, Africa

Tribes Practising Shifting Cultivation

Gonds, Baiga, Kukis, Maler

The Process of Shifting Cultivation



Sustainability Dimensions

Dimension	Detail
 Ecological Balance	Fallow regeneration; soil restoration; forest regrowth; mixed cropping
Social Regulation	Community-owned land; collective decision-making; prevents conflict
Cultural Integration	Rituals before clearing; post-harvest ceremonies; gratitude to nature
Gender and Labour	Men clear and burn; women sow and weed — balanced gender division

Changes and Challenges

- Govt restrictions on burning shorten fallow cycles, reducing fertility
- Monocropping and cash crop introduction disturb ecological balance
- Sedentarisation schemes ignore socio-ecological wisdom

FAO (2019)

Traditional shifting cultivation **CAN be sustainable** if customary laws and long fallows maintained.

Case Studies

(a) Maler Tribe — Rajmahal Hills, Jharkhand

- Also called **Paharia**
- Small-scale rotational shifting cultivation on forested hill slopes
- **Crops:** Millets, pulses, maize, cucurbits, roots
- **Customs:** Ritual offering to local deities before cutting; community fire control rules; taboos near springs and sacred groves

 **ICAR + ASI:** Traditional Maler jhum more ecologically stable than commercial monocropping — preserves carbon, prevents erosion.

(b) Baiga Tribe — Maikal Hills, MP & Chhattisgarh

- **Practice:** *Bewar* cultivation — burning dry vegetation, sowing mixed crops on hill slopes
- Customary laws enforced by village elders and clan heads
- **Taboos:** Felling fruit-bearing trees (mahua, mango, tamarind) **strictly prohibited**
- Sacred groves preserved for ritual and biodiversity
- Ash = natural fertiliser; minimal tillage prevents soil compaction

 **L.P. Vidyarthi (1963)** — **Nature-Man-Spirit Complex** — economic activity, ecology, and belief form an integrated system.

4. Settled Agriculture

Features

Feature	Detail
Settled life	Permanent rural and urban settlement
High population density	Higher than other economic types
Complex economic resources	Land, tools, markets
Complex technology	Ploughing, irrigation
Division of labour	Based on age and sex
Land ownership	Private / hereditary
Full-time political leadership	Village headman, councils

Examples

Santhals, Mundas, Oraons, Gonds, Baiga

Case Studies

(a) Santhals — Jharkhand, WB, Odisha, Bihar

- One of the **largest tribal groups** in India
- **Location:** Chotanagpur Plateau — rolling uplands and forested plains
- Settled plough cultivation, mainly monsoon rain-fed
- **Main crops:** Rice, millets, pulses, maize, oilseeds
- **Land:** Hereditary and patrilineal. **Labour:** Family-based + reciprocal exchange “*parma*”
- Village headman (**Manjhi**) oversees agricultural arrangements
- Agriculture interwoven with religious life — rituals before sowing and after harvest
- **Deity:** Marang Buru (Great Mountain Spirit)
- **Festivals:** Sohrai (cattle, fertility) and Baha (agricultural cycle)

 **N.K. Bose** — Santhal agriculture represents a **bridge between subsistence economy and market participation**.



(b) Apatani Rice-Fish Cultivation System — Arunachal Pradesh

- **Location:** Ziro Valley, Lower Subansiri District — high-altitude wetland
- **UNIQUE** integrated rice-fish farming — most sophisticated indigenous practice in NE India
- Rice and fish cultivated **TOGETHER** in same wet field
- Terraced fields + bamboo irrigation channels + wooden sluices
- Common carp (*Cyprinus carpio*) introduced after rice transplantation
- Fish eat insects/weeds (*natural pest control*); waste adds nutrients (*natural fertiliser*)
- Community collectively manages irrigation — strong communal institutions



FAO recognised: Globally Important Agricultural Heritage Systems (**GIAHS**)

Comparison: Santhals vs Apatanis

Aspect	Santhals	Apatanis
Type	Subsistence to settled plough	Advanced integrated rice-fish
Innovation	<i>Parma</i> (reciprocal labour)	Rice-fish co-cultivation
Common	Both combine traditional ecological knowledge with community cooperation	

5. Tribal Artisans

Major Crafts

Craft	Tribes
Basket Making (Bamboo)	Bhils, Santhals, Nagas
Tool Making (Iron & Wood)	Agarias, Lohars
Spinning & Weaving	Gonds, Kotas, Apatanis
Pottery	Kumbhars, Santhals

 **TRIFED**

Est. **1987** under Ministry of Tribal Affairs. Promotes tribal handicrafts through **TRIBES India** outlets. Implements **Van Dhan Yojana** and **MSP for MFP**.

Case Studies

 **(a) Asur Tribe — Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Bihar (PVTG)**

- **Location:** Gumla and Latehar, Jharkhand
- One of the **earliest iron-smelting communities** in India
- **Technique:** Primitive bloomery furnace — small clay furnaces; bellows from animal skin; charcoal
- **Products:** Sickles, ploughshares, knives, arrowheads — indigenous metallurgical knowledge system
- **Decline:** Industrial steel plants (Tata, Bokaro) + Forest Dept restrictions
- **Cultural:** Iron sacred; mythical ancestor Asura Raja; festivals Sarhul and Karma invoke Iron God
- **Today:** Mostly agricultural labourers; some continue blacksmithing as cultural/symbolic occupation



(b) Agaria Tribe — MP, Chhattisgarh, UP, Jharkhand

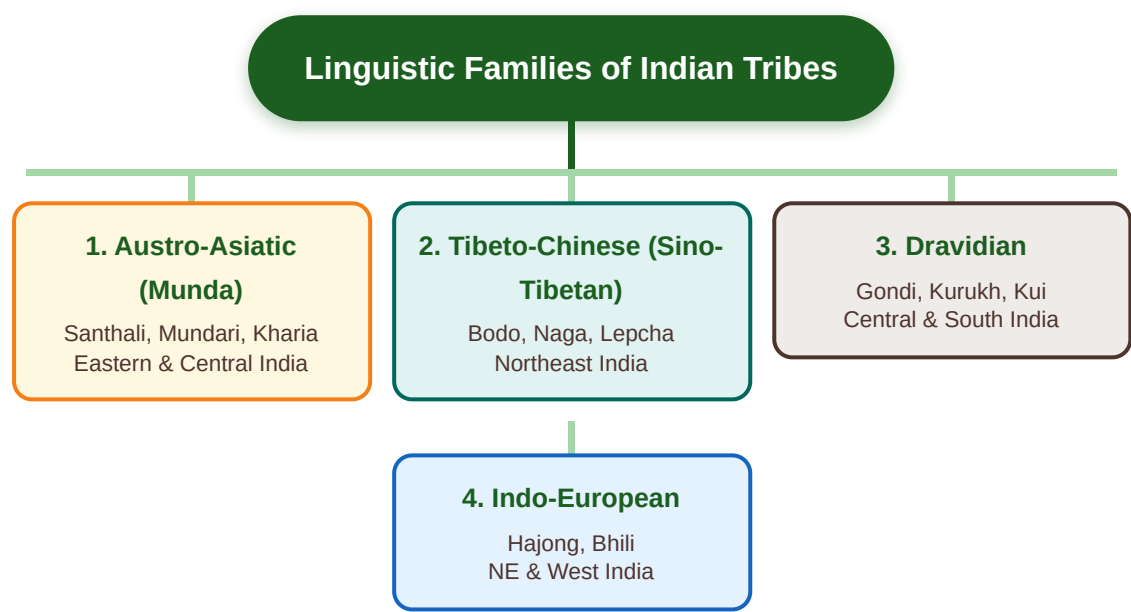
- Sub-group of Gonds; traditionally iron smelters
- Name from “*agar*” = furnace in local dialects
- **Locations:** Sidhi, Shahdol, Mandla (MP); Sonbhadra (UP); Bilaspur (CG)
- **Technique:** Pit furnaces lined with clay/stone; bamboo bellows; charcoal fuel
- Smelting villages = industrial clusters — early division of labour
- **Today:** Agriculture, daily labour; some continue via TRIFED/Van Dhan outlets

6. Agricultural and Industrial Labourers

- Many tribes became **landless labourers** due to colonial policies and historical/economic pressures
- Work on others' land for wages (cash, kind, or crop share)
- Colonial policies led to large-scale **land alienation** and forced displacement
- **Examples:** Santhals and Oraons lost traditional land, depend on wage labour
- Some engage in **seasonal migration** during lean agricultural seasons

Section 2: Linguistic Classification of Tribes

India has over **700 tribal groups**, each with a distinct language or dialect. They are classified into **four main linguistic families**.



Summary of Linguistic Families

Family	Key Languages	Region	Antiquity
Austro-Asiatic (Munda)	Santhali, Mundari, Kharia	Eastern & Central India	One of earliest in S. Asia (Anderson, 2008)
Tibeto-Chinese (Sino-Tibetan)	Bodo, Naga, Lepcha	Northeast India	Affinities with E/SE Asia
Dravidian	Gondi, Kurukh, Kui	Central & South India	At least 4,000 years (Krishnamurti, 2003)
Indo-European	Hajong, Bhili	NE & West India	Contact and assimilation layers

1. Austro-Asiatic Family

- Over **150 languages**, 100+ million speakers across SE Asia and South Asia
- In India: primarily eastern and central regions

Scholars on Origin

 **W. Schmidt** — Named Munda language as **Austro-Asiatic**.

 **Heine Geldern (1928)** — Mongoloid people entered India from NE, brought Munda languages which spread to middle India.

 **Hutton** — Austro-Asiatic brought by **Kolarians** through west end of Himalayas; Mon Khmer speakers from east.

 **Suniti Kumar Chatterji** — Certain nouns in Hindi, Punjabi, Bengali **borrowed from Munda** languages.

Two Branches in India

(a) Mon-Khmer

- **Khasi** (Meghalaya)
- **Nicobari** (Nicobar Islands)

(b) Munda

- Santhali, Kherwari, Ho, Mundari, Gondi, Kharia, Savara, Khond, Gadaba
- **Santhali** = one of the largest (Jharkhand, WB, Odisha, Bihar)

 **Unique Feature:** System of **phonetic tones** distinguishes it from other families.

2. Tibeto-Chinese (Sino-Tibetan) Family

Divided into: **Siamese-Chinese** and **Tibeto-Burman**

(a) Siamese-Chinese

Tribe	Details
Tai-Khampti	Major tribe of Arunachal Pradesh; Namsai district; name means “land full of gold”; Theravada (Hinayana) Buddhism
Tai Phake (Phakial)	Small tribe of Assam (~2,000); migrated from Thailand in late 18th century

(b) Tibeto-Burman — 4 Branches

Branch	Tribes / Languages
1. Tibeto-Himalayan	Bhotia (Darjeeling); Chamba, Lahauli, Swangli, Kanauri
2. Non-Pronominalized Himalayan	Rong/Lepcha, Toto (West Bengal)
3. Arunachal	Aka/Hrusso, Abor, Miri, Dafla
4. Assam-Burmese	Bara/Bodo group: Kachari, Dimasa, Garo, Tripura Naga group: Angami, Ao, Sema, Rengma Kachin: Singpho Kuki-Chin: Manipuri, Thado, Sokte, Ralte, Lushai

3. Dravidian Family

250 million speakers; predominantly southern India.

 **Robert Caldwell (1856)** — Published “**Comparative Grammar of Dravidian or South-Indian Family of Languages**” — established Dravidian as a major world language family.

 **Krishnamurti (2003)** — Dravidian languages trace back **at least 4,000 years** — predating Indo-Aryan expansion.

 **Earliest evidence:** 2nd century BCE Tamil-Brahmi script in Madurai and Tirunelveli.

Major Dravidian Languages (%)

Language	% of Dravidian Speakers
Telugu	34.5%
Tamil	29%
Kannada	15.4%
Malayalam	14.4%
Gondi	1.2%
Brahui	0.9%
Kurukh	0.8%
Tulu	0.7%

Dravidian STs

- **Kurukh** (Eastern India)
- **Gondi** (Central India)

Outside India

- **Brahui** (Balochistan, Pakistan)
- **Dhangar** (Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh)
- **Tamil** (NE Sri Lanka)

4. Indo-European Family

Origins

- **Origin:** Proto-Indo-European homeland = Pontic-Caspian Steppe (modern Ukraine, S. Russia, Kazakhstan) around **4000–3000 BCE**
- **Expansion:** Westward to Europe; Southeast to South Asia (Indo-Iranian branch)
- **Indo-Aryan:** Sanskrit (Vedic, c.1500 BCE) → Hindi, Bengali, Marathi, etc.
- **Iranian:** Old Persian, Avestan → Persian, Pashto



Marija Gimbutas — **Kurgan Hypothesis** — PIE homeland on the Pontic-Caspian Steppe.

Tribal Examples

Hajong (Eastern Indo-Aryan)

- **Location:** Meghalaya, Assam, Arunachal Pradesh
- Indo-Aryan dialect influenced by Tibeto-Burman
- Mixed Hindu-animistic practices
- **Festivals:** Chorkhela and Pusne

Bhili (Western Indo-Aryan)

- Bhils of Rajasthan, MP, Gujarat, Maharashtra
- Bhili dialects show **Dravidian and Munda influences**

Glottochronology



Morris Swadesh (1950s) — Proposed **glottochronology** — estimates when languages diverged by rate of loss of shared core vocabulary.

- **Indo-Iranian split from PIE:** c.2000–1800 BCE
- **Indo-Aryan migration into India:** c.1500 BCE



Colin Masica (1991) — Indo-Aryan languages **became majority tongue** of the subcontinent.

Significance

 **Abbi (2017)** — Survival of Austro-Asiatic and Tibeto-Burman demonstrates **deep antiquity and diversity** of tribal linguistic heritage.

 Tribal languages preserve **older strata** of India's linguistic history compared to later Indo-Aryan dominance.

Endangered Languages

 **Key Statistics**

- India has **19,500+** languages/dialects
- 2nd largest** number of endangered languages in world
- UNESCO: **197 endangered + 42 critically endangered**
- 1961 Census: 1,652 languages; PLSI (2010): only **780 documented**
- 68 living scripts; newspapers in 35 languages; AIR broadcasts in 120 languages
- Hindi (40%), Bengali (8%), Telugu (7.1%), Marathi (6.9%), Tamil (5.9%)
- Only **4%** of India's languages represented in Parliament
- Linguistic diversity highest in: Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Odisha, WB, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan

Critically Endangered Languages

Language	Region	Status
Majhi	Sikkim	Only 4 speakers — one family!
Birhor	Central India	2,000 speakers
Asur	Jharkhand	UNESCO endangered
Korwa	Jharkhand	UNESCO endangered
Koro	Arunachal Pradesh	Endangered
Sidi	Gujarat	Endangered
Dimasa	Assam	Endangered
Mahali	Eastern India	Endangered

Reasons for Language Endangerment

- Major regional language dominance
- Loss of traditional knowledge
- Youth migration
- Loss of intergenerational transmission

Government Initiatives

#	Initiative	Details
1	CIIL	Central Institute of Indian Languages, est. 1969, Mysore
2	PLSI	People's Linguistic Survey, 2010
3	SPPEL	CIIL works on languages spoken by less than 10,000 people; 117 languages on priority
4	MLE Programme	Odisha, 2006 — 3,385 tribal language teachers; dictionaries for 20 tribal languages
5	MTBMLE	KISS in Odisha teaches 10 tribal dialects
6	8th Schedule Push	2018: Odisha proposed inclusion of Ho, Mundari, Bhumji in Eighth Schedule
7	Strategies	Documentation, bilingual education, community radios (Asur tribe uses radio to revitalise language)

All Scholars — Quick Reference (Part 1)

 Scholar	Key Contribution
Marshall Sahlins	“Original Affluent Society”
L.P. Vidyarthi (1963)	Nature-Man-Spirit Complex
N.K. Bose	Santhal agriculture bridges subsistence & market
W. Schmidt	Named Munda as Austro-Asiatic
Heine Geldern (1928)	Mongoloids brought Munda from NE
Hutton	Austro-Asiatic via Kolarians from west Himalayas
Suniti K. Chatterji	Hindi/Bengali nouns borrowed from Munda
Robert Caldwell (1856)	Comparative Grammar of Dravidian Languages
Krishnamurti (2003)	Dravidian = 4,000+ years old
Marija Gimbutas	Kurgan Hypothesis
Morris Swadesh (1950s)	Glottochronology
Colin Masica (1991)	Indo-Aryan became majority tongue
Abbi (2017)	Deep antiquity of tribal linguistic heritage
Anderson (2008)	Munda = earliest language family in S. Asia

End of Part 1

Occupational & Linguistic Classifications of Indian Tribes

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